Assignment 5

Problem Brief v2 - Package Returns

Nov 7, 2026

Where we are now

People abandon, delay or avoid returns not because starting one is hard, but because physically getting the package to an accepting drop-off is. Our first answer, a team-run doorstep pickup, did not hold up: stated willingness to pay sits near $5 per package, and the economics of a dedicated pickup did not cover its cost. We have since reframed the idea as a marketplace that matches returns to gig drivers already nearby, and our latest interview suggests the driver side is the weakest link. Uber and DoorDash already offer return pickup, so our open question is no longer "is this possible?" but "why has it not taken off, and who would pay for it to?"

Evidence base: 19 documented interviews across five learning logs (shoppers, one Lyft driver), plus short conversations with Duke mail-center and USPS-counter staff. One persona in Learning Log 3 was explicitly simulated and is not counted as validation. Most participants are Duke students or live near campus.

WRAP applied

Step	What we did	Status
Widen your options	Moved past one solution. Options on the table: team-run doorstep pickup (v1); a gig-driver matching marketplace (current); retailer-funded returns; box-free, label-free drop-off partnerships like Happy Returns; bundling into retailer apps such as Walmart's; consolidated pickup at an apartment building's common point. We also counted the competing behaviors: keep the item, resell it, donate it, or throw it away.	Done

Reality-test your assumptions	Used one interview guide anchored on a specific past return, quotes kept verbatim. Showed the BlueDash prototype before explaining it. Interviewed mail-center and USPS staff. Checked official services from USPS, Happy Returns, Uber and DoorDash. Looked for disconfirming evidence on purpose: one Lyft driver, and a simulated persona we refused to count as validation.	Done for shopper side; driver side only n=1
Attain distance before deciding	Outreach has started to product leaders at DoorDash, Uber and Lyft alumni, and marketplace founders to ask what they tried and why it stalled. We have no completed conversations to report yet.	In progress
Prepare to be wrong	Wrote down what would make us stop or change course for each key assumption (see the last section) and removed claims the evidence did not support, such as "first mover."	Started

MVP assumptions tested so far

Assumption	How we tested it	Result	Verdict
Frequent shoppers mainly struggle with tracking return deadlines and refunds	Same 10-question guide across 4 interviews (Log 1)	Starting a return was easy for everyone; the physical trip was the problem. Car access, distance, item size and pickup availability explained friction better than shopping frequency	Disproved; we changed our segmentation
Time to an accepting drop-off matters more than owning a car	Logs 2 and 3 (7 interviews)	A 3-minute walk meant little friction; a car owner with a 40-minute round trip held boxes for 1-2 weeks; another	Supported by a few cases; needs more

		car owner took ~10 days with a large box and two children	
People will pay for doorstep return pickup	Stated-price questions in Logs 1-4, plus BlueDash price tests	Amounts cluster around $5 per package (details below). No one has paid or completed a booking	Weak: stated, not revealed
A monthly membership beats pay-per-use	Logs 3 and 4	Most preferred pay-per-use; one liked $10-20 a month; one wanted a seasonal plan	Mostly disproved
People will understand the BlueDash prototype	Log 3 (3 interviews)	One understood it at once; one took it for a tracking site; one read it as a mailroom service and took the PILOT label to mean "not ready"	Partly: returns option not visible enough
People will hand a package to a stranger	Logs 1-4	Trust is conditional on proof the package reaches the carrier, damage terms and verified couriers	Open
Existing options leave a gap	Interviews plus checking USPS, Happy Returns, Uber and DoorDash	Strong substitutes exist: free Walmart in-app pickup, Amazon returns at Whole Foods with no box, free USPS pickup, and Uber and DoorDash return pickup	Not a gap by default; our "first mover" claim was removed
Hard returns change what people buy	Logs 2 and 4	Several said they order less, measure before buying, or	Supported in stories; not sized

		choose Amazon because of Whole Foods drop-off	
Gig drivers will take return jobs between rides	Log 5 (1 Lyft driver)	Not interested; his real pain was juggling Uber and Lyft; some drivers can't walk to doors	Not supported; highest risk, n=1

We also learned from mail-center and USPS-counter staff that Duke's mailbox handles inbound only, the campus desk takes only pre-printed USPS labels without QR codes, and UPS or oversized returns need an off-campus trip.

Willingness-to-pay insights

Shoppers will say about $5 per package, but nobody has paid, and $5 is unlikely to fund a driver's detour.

What people told us	Amount (stated)
Per-package, small items (Log 4: 3 people; Log 3: 2 people)	About $5; $3 - 5; $3.99 when short on time; Leo accepted a $4.99 cap
Per-package, with box and printed label provided	$5 - 10 (counting ~$5 for box and label,$ ~5 for the pickup)
Seasonal user with free Walmart pickup available	$5, up to $5 - 10 at most
Small, cheap items	"A couple of bucks, basically gas money"
Bulky or long-distance items	$50 - 100

Monthly plan (1 person, ~5-8 items)	$10 – 20; above $20 they would use UPS

What this means

- **The anchor is low and consistent.** Most per-package answers sit between $3 and $10, centered near $5.
- **Willingness rises with size, value and distance.** Bulky items and long trips justify more; small items do not.
- **The box and label matter as much as the pickup.** One participant said having them provided was "one of the bigger factors."
- **Pay-per-use beats subscription** for most people, with one heavy returner and one seasonal user as exceptions.
- **Free alternatives cap the price.** Walmart's in-app pickup, free USPS pickup, and Amazon's no-box Whole Foods drop-off make paying hard to justify.
- **The cost of not returning is small per item.** Examples: a ~$20 item thrown away, a $30 item abandoned, and a couple hundred dollars lost in a year. That limits what a shopper will pay to avoid it.
- **There is some real spend.** One participant used Uber for a Zara return and another paid $3 – 5 at a store to print a label. No one has paid for a return service.

Every number above is a stated answer, not a purchase. We have not yet seen anyone book or pay.

How the idea has changed

We have made three small changes and one large pivot, and the evidence now points to another large change on the supply side.

Change	Size	Why
Segment people by time to an accepting drop-off, item size and pickup availability, not by how often they shop	Small	Log 1 showed that starting a return is easy and the trip is the problem; Log 2 showed car ownership alone doesn't predict friction

Treat returns as more valuable than mailroom pickup, and look at delivery problems that came up unprompted	Small	Log 2 interviewees said delivery bothered them more than returns; Log 3 found returns require a 10-15 minute trip while incoming packages do not
Move from a monthly membership to pay-per-use with a visible maximum charge	Small to medium	Most participants preferred pay-per-use; one did not understand a 25% membership discount
Move from a team-run doorstep pickup to a platform that matches returns with gig drivers already nearby	Large	Stated willingness to pay was low and the economics of a dedicated pickup didn't add up
Next, likely: decide who pays (a retailer rather than the shopper) and which drivers can do door-to-door work	Large, not yet made	Our first driver interview was not interested in returns and some drivers can't walk to doors; Uber and DoorDash already offer return pickup

What we dropped: the claim that we are a first mover, the idea that cost savings would hit retailers' outbound delivery, and acquisition as evidence of demand.

What we held onto: the core problem. Across 19 interviews the pain of physically completing a return has not gone away, even as every proposed solution has been questioned.

Assumptions to test next

Ranked by how badly the idea fails if we are wrong. The stop signals are our proposals and the team should confirm the numbers.

#	Assumption	Test	Stop or change course if

1	Someone will pay enough per return to fund a driver's detour, most likely a retailer rather than the shopper	Interview 5-8 retailer returns or operations people; ask for a small paid or funded pilot	No retailer will fund even a small pilot
2	Drivers will take return jobs at a payout that beats their detour, wait and lost work	Interview 10+ drivers who do rides and delivery (record with permission); hand-match returns to 5 drivers' real routes and track minutes, miles and net pay	Few drivers say yes to a concrete payout and detour limit, and none complete a real job
3	Shoppers will actually book at about $5, not just say they would	Offer pre-booking to one apartment community; count bookings and refusals	Almost no one books when asked to commit
4	We can do something Uber and DoorDash return pickup doesn't	Ask people who have worked on those products why they haven't taken off; compare completed returns, not features	The reason is structural, such as carrier rules or economics we can't change
5	People trust a stranger with a package if they get proof of carrier receipt	Concierge pilot with photo and carrier receipt sent to the shopper; track disputes and repeat use	Losses or disputes outweigh the convenience

The first two decide whether this is a business. The others decide how to build it.